speedboats, “attacked” a frigate, clambered up its cable ladders while shooting 9-mm MP5s loaded with paintball rounds. In one exercise we scurried down a flight of metal stairs into the frigate’s hold. Someone cut the lights, to make it more interesting, I suppose. In the pitch-dark, four steps from the bottom, I fell, landed on my left knee, which was immediately impaled on a fixed bolt sticking out of the floor.

Blinding pain washed over me.

I managed to get up, keep going, finish the drill. But at the end of the exercise we jumped off the boat’s helipad, into the water, and I found my knee wasn’t working. My whole leg wasn’t working. When I got out of the water and stripped off the dry suit, Willy looked down and turned pale.

My knee was gushing blood.

Paramedics were there within minutes.

The Palace announced some weeks later that my entry into the Army would be postponed. Indefinitely.

Reporters demanded to know why.

The Palace comms team told them: *Prince Harry has injured his knee playing rugby.*

Reading the papers, my leg iced and elevated, I threw back my head and laughed. I couldn’t help savoring one small particle of self-indulgent glee as the papers, for once, *unwittingly* printed a lie about me.

They soon got their revenge, however. They began pushing a story that I was *afraid* to go into the Army, that I was bunking off, using a fake knee injury as a way of stalling.

I was, they said, a coward.

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One of Willy’s friends was having a birthday party. In the countryside near Gloucestershire. More than a birthday party, it was a fancy-dress party, with a cringy theme. Natives and colonials. Guests were *required* to dress accordingly.

January 2005.